

WHAT'S LIKE GOT TO DO WITH IT?

Evanston author Sara Levine on the art of "difficult" women. **A+E**

STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

LIFE+TRAVEL
Thailand escape
Island of Koh Lan offers antidote to "White Lotus" frenzy two hours from Bangkok.

REAL ESTATE
Dream vs. reality
Buying a home can seem like a dream come true, but the real cost can be steep.

Field of mayoral hopefuls growing

Well-funded potential challengers already circling Johnson

By Jake Sheridan, A.D. Quig and Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

Four years ago, the first Chicago mayoral hopefuls were months away from announcing their campaigns. This time around, the line is already out the door.

A large and growing field of candidates is angling to take out Mayor Brandon Johnson, who is seen as very beatable. New campaign finance records showing a couple of likely challengers holding commanding leads in fundraising over the freshman incumbent drive home the tough battle he faces.

And as members of the crowded slate jockey for money and support, many are casting Johnson as political carrion.

"I think the public's made up their mind about him," said U.S. Rep. Mike Quigley, who promised to jump in the competition earlier this month. "This is a city in crisis. I think people get it."

As of the end of 2025, Johnson had \$830,000 on hand, trailing potential candidates Illinois Comptroller Susana Mendoza and Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulias, who were sitting on \$1.6 million and \$6.35 million, respectively.

Altogether, six politicians who have declared for the race or

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Illinois' oil crisis

Once a top producer, the state has mismanaged funds and needs \$160M to plug thousands of abandoned wells that can contaminate groundwater and kill crops

By Jonathan Bullington and Adriana Pérez | Chicago Tribune

CRAWFORD COUNTY — Bill Rosborough and his son Jon stopped their pickup truck near a 40-acre cornfield and pointed to a white PVC pipe that rose 5 feet from the snow-covered ground on a windy December afternoon.

The Rosboroughs farm this land and placed the pipe to mark the spot where an oil well once stood.

"I don't even know that we've found the casing yet," Jon Rosborough said. "It's just a hole."

He crouched by a small pool of liquid near the pipe, obscured by stalks of dead grass. The faint rainbow sheen of oil was visible.

State records show the well extends 965 feet below ground, drilled in March 1916. Neither Rosborough knew who was responsible for it today.

"I don't know what its official status is," Jon Rosborough said, "but as you can see, they've not been here in a while, let's put it that way."

Thousands of similarly abandoned oil and gas wells are strewn across southern Illinois, remnants of a distant past when the state was one of the nation's top oil producers. They litter farm fields, hide in woods and abut waterways. Many are called "orphans" by the state, their owners dead or unidentified, their companies bankrupted by a notoriously volatile global industry punctuated with booms and busts.

Left unplugged, some of these wells leak toxic chemicals hundreds of feet below the surface, potentially contaminating groundwater, and spit climate-warming methane gas into the atmosphere. They allow underground fluid called brine — several times saltier than seawater — to spill onto

Above: Jon Rosborough inspects an abandoned oil well on Dec. 15 that was drilled in 1916 on land his family farms in Crawford County near Oblong. Thousands of abandoned oil and gas wells are strewn across southern Illinois, in farm fields, woods and abutting waterways. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

fertile farmlands, killing crops and leaving a virtually dead zone of soil that can take years to fix.

While oil companies are responsible for mitigating those risks by plugging wells that have stopped producing, there are nearly 4,000 abandoned oil and gas wells that are currently unplugged — holes, essentially, left behind for the Illinois Department of Natural Resources to close.

And for years, the state has fallen woefully short of the task, the Tribune has learned after reviewing hundreds of pages of public records and conducting more than two dozen interviews with southern Illinois farmers, oil industry representatives, environmental scientists and advocates. The paper's three-month investigation found the state has mismanaged millions

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INSIDE

Trump threatens tariffs on 8 allies

The president said he would charge a 10% import tax on nations opposed to American control of Greenland. **Nation & World**

'CLEAN SLATE': Two million Illinois residents could have convictions for nonviolent crimes automatically sealed under new law. **Page 3**

A Bears cheer team member waves a "Bear Down" flag after a field goal in the third quarter of a preseason game against the Titans at Soldier Field on Aug. 12, 2023, in Chicago. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

How 'Bear Down' became Chicago's rallying cry

By Andrew Carter
Chicago Tribune

It will be a freezing cold Sunday night at Soldier Field, where the wind will be bitter and spectators warmed by libations and layers, and where, with any luck for those frigid, bundled masses, they will celebrate in unison as often as possible with their beloved anthem.

The song may well be louder that night, if the circumstances align. It may well be sung with more reverence. There may be more fervency upon its singing throughout the old stadium. And if it all happens the way the Bears and their supporters hope, the words may echo deep into the city:

NFC DIVISIONAL PLAYOFFS
 Rams at Bears
5:30 p.m. Sunday, NBC-5

DEFYING THE ODDS: Bears have been winning with flair for dramatic. Can they keep it up? **Sports**

'PERCOLATOR': As the Bears gain momentum, the house music staple rises with them. **Page 4**

BEEEAAR DOOOWWWN, CHICAGO BEARS!

During home games, the music plays every time the Bears score. The familiar melody begins. The words erupt, with tens of thou-

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